



were the Communists who declared their support to the "People's War", to defend the Soviet Union against the Nazis. But more crucially, the British exploited Muslim anxiety about the impending Congress hegemony. Jinnah had long demanded equality for Muslims, arguing that a minority status should not mean being a "minor" part of independent India. This desire for equality was the driving force behind the two-nation theory and the demand for Pakistan. Could India be an independent state while acknowledging that it contained multiple and equal "nationalities", they asked. The Gandhi-Ambedkar disagreement in the 1930s had posed a similar question. Echoes of it could also be heard in the rise of the Dravidian movement. By the 1940s, however, this broad challenge to rethink the relationship between socio-cultural multiplicity and citizenship was reduced to the Hindu-Muslim question. As Congress insisted that the nation was single and homogeneous, which it alone represented and Jinnah asserted that he was the "sole spokesman" for the Muslims, the opportunity was lost for crafting political answers for communal and social conflicts.

The 1945-46 elections exposed the fracture of communal divisions. Congress won 90 per cent of non-Muslim seats in the Central Legislature while the Muslim League swept the Muslim reserved positions in the Centre and provinces. Emboldened, both turned intransigent. Nehru declared in April 1946 that the Congress would be free to override any previous agreements for provincial autonomy, if it came in

the way of the Centre's plans for national development. In Jinnah's eyes, this was proof of the Congress's perfidy. With mass politics firmly in place, discord at the top tumbled quickly onto the streets. Jinnah called for "direct action," and communal slaughter commenced. Thousands perished between August 16 and 20 in the great Calcutta killing. Despite Gandhi's calls for non-violence, much of northern and eastern India plunged into chaos. Killings and revenge killings prevailed and a united India was now impossible.

In retreat after the battering of the war and anti-colonial upheavals, the British partitioned the subcontinent. India and Pakistan came into existence as independent nations in August 1947, bathed in the blood of communal butchery. The different communities fought pitched battles and trainloads of massacred Hindus, Sikhs, and Muslims rode in ghostly silence into the railway stations of the new nations. More than a million lost their lives and over 12 million were

uprooted and forced to reconstruct their lives in the new nations. Thousands of women were raped, kidnapped and forcibly married to their captors. The violence left deep scars and the trauma of the birth of the two nations went on to haunt their futures.

While Nehru marked August 15, 1947, with an eloquent speech about India's "tryst with destiny", Gandhi heroically preached the message of non-violence and communal peace. But his message was lost on the Hindu communalist eager to build a muscular and modern Hindu nation-state. On January 30, 1948, Hindu fanatic Nathuram Godse murdered Gandhi, and a tearful Nehru mourned that the "light has gone out of our lives". With Gandhi gone, the Congress scrambled to establish state authority, manage the accession of princely states, including Kashmir, and stave off the Communist-led Telangana insurrection. The Constituent Assembly met from 1947 to 1949 to lay the basis for a modern democratic polity.

As the new decade opened, a lot had changed. The British Empire was gone from the subcontinent, India was an independent republic, and the era of democratic politics had taken root. But the price paid was Partition, millions of lost and uprooted lives, and an inheritance of communal conflict. The promise was freedom, justice, and prosperity for ordinary citizens—yet to be fulfilled.

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